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features

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SEGA DREAMCAST GAME REVIEW: Marvel vs Capcom 2
SALLY TAYLOR PLUGS IN: The daughter of Carly Simon and James Taylor connects with her audience online
NEVER BUY SOFTWARE AGAIN: 'Pay-per-view' providers put it all online
N64 GAME REVIEW: Rally Challenge 2000
DIGITAL DIVA: A 'Net program jumps to TV; Jailcam inmates pretty in pink

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When 'Love' Comes to Town

Easy tips to save your data from virus infection

By Mike Talon



Illustration by Daniela Stinger

A friend e-mails you a joke. You open it up and find there's nothing in the attachment. Then your phone starts ringing off the hook; you've sent a virus to everyone in your address book, and they're not happy.

You've just gotten hit with a "Trojan Horse" virus that disguises itself as a very innocent file. It can be from anyone, since these virus files multiply by sending copies of themselves out via e-mail without the user's knowledge. Your mother could be sending you a casual hello e-mail right now that could wipe out your computer. How do you protect yourself and your data? Don't worry, it's not as hard as you think.

Use protection

Your first line of defense is reputable anti-virus software that scans every file you try to open. You can purchase Symantec's Norton Anti-Virus 2000 online or at a software shop. After you install the software, make sure you constantly update it. All major anti-virus vendors have Web sites where you can download updates on a regular basis (usually every 15 days), and many have software built in to automatically get the updates for you.

If you use Microsoft Windows with Internet Explorer 4 or higher, be sure to check out windowsupdate.microsoft.com regularly. By going to "Product Updates," you can download the newest security patches to protect yourself.

For those of you on MacOS, don't think you're safe from harm. A lot of virus files damage Macs just as easily as PCs, so make sure you're using a virus scanner, too.

Do what the experts do

Unfortunately, these scanners don't pick up all viruses, so how do you shield yourself from unknown threats? Keep them unknown. Never open an e-mail attachment that comes from someone you don't know, and don't open unexpected attachments, even if you know the sender. If you're leery, e-mail the sender and ask them what they're sending you and where they got it from.

Be sure to only download software from reputable sites. Be really careful with "shareware" and "freeware," which could carry something you really don't want.

Keep in mind that ICQ, AOL Instant Messenger and other systems that let you send and receive messages can be problematic as well. Use the same guidelines as you do for e-mail.

Keep surfin'

Don't let viruses keep you from your usual Web activity. There are very few known e-mail viruses that can infect you just by reading the e-mail, and these should all be detected by anti-virus software. Again, stay away from opening attachments, and you should be okay. Many of the horror stories you hear are merely urban legends; you can find all of these listed at www.SARC.com. Take heart—if it sounds too bad to be true, it probably is.

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